STIVEN CATALYST

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MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



ROLE

MANAGING UP: THE RELATIONSHIP WITH YOUR BOSS

A case of 14 months from Gabarro and Kotter, what 40 employees did not tell their bosses, five parts of a working relationship, two views of one relationship, seven questions and a card for the talk.

85% of 40 employees interviewed had at least once felt unable to raise an issue with their bosses, although they thought it important.

MILLIKEN, MORRISON & HEWLIN, 2003

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NO. 52 · ROLE

In this issue

Most of what is written for managers looks down, at the team. Yet every manager also has a boss, who sets priorities, opens doors and decides on resources. Here we look up: at what the relationship with the boss needs, what gets in its way, and what a manager can do about it.

In 1980 John Gabarro and John Kotter described managing the boss as working consciously with your superior for the best results for both and for the company, not as flattery. Of 40 employees interviewed in 2003, 34 had at least once felt unable to raise an important issue with their bosses. Leader–member exchange research describes how the relationship grows from strangers to partners. Meta-analyses find that boss and employee rate it only moderately alike. Seven questions make it measurable.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

Fourteen months

Gabarro and Kotter open with a case. Frank Gibbons, a manufacturing vice president, was strong on production and weak with people. Philip Bonnevie, who had always had good bosses, was promoted to report to him in 1975 and never thought that managing his boss was part of his job. Fourteen months later he was fired.

During a major product launch the two disagreed about what had been agreed: a new type of machinery, how much risk to take. A plant was built that could not make the product as planned. The company lost $2 million to $5 million, by the authors' account. Gibbons blamed Bonnevie, Bonnevie blamed Gibbons.

01

What the boss needs from you

cooperation, dependability and honesty

02

What you need from the boss

links to the rest of the company, priorities that fit, resources

OUR READING

Gibbons's weakness was known to everyone. What was missing was a subordinate who took it into account.

Source: John J. Gabarro & John P. Kotter, Harvard Business Review, 1980 (via Best of HBR reprint, January 2005)

The case is told by Gabarro and Kotter (1980), from events of the 1970s; we know it only from their account. The two lists follow their article; what we draw from them is our own.

THE NUMBERS

What does not travel up

Frances Milliken, Elizabeth Morrison and Patricia Hewlin interviewed 40 people in full-time jobs. 34 of them (85%) had at least once felt unable to raise an issue with their bosses, although they thought it important. Only 51% generally felt comfortable speaking up.

WHY THEY STAYED SILENT (SHARE OF THE 40 WHO NAMED EACH REASON), 2003



Held back most often: the competence or performance of a colleague or boss (37.5%), problems with processes (35%) and pay (27.5%).

OUR READING

The news a boss needs most is often the news hardest to bring. Waiting to be asked is not enough.

Source: Frances J. Milliken, Elizabeth W. Morrison & Patricia F. Hewlin, Journal of Management Studies 40(6), 2003 (via Authors' manuscript)

Exploratory study: 40 interviews with full-time employees taking part-time MBA classes; the shares describe only this sample. Most named several reasons.

THE MODEL

Understand, then build

Gabarro and Kotter's checklist has three parts: understand the boss, understand yourself, and build a relationship that fits both. A boss, they write, is a fallible human being with limited time and their own pressures.

Understand	Build
the boss's goals and pressures	compatible work styles
strengths, weaknesses, blind spots	expectations spelled out on both sides
the boss's preferred way of working	a flow of information, bad news included
your own style and attitude to authority	dependability and honesty
	selective use of the boss's time

Following Peter Drucker, they split bosses into readers and listeners. A listener is briefed in person, then gets a memo; a reader gets the memo first, then the talk.

OUR READING

Managing up means sparing the boss the guesswork. Pleasing the boss is another matter.

Source: John J. Gabarro & John P. Kotter, Harvard Business Review, 1980 (via Best of HBR reprint, January 2005)

Grouping after the authors' checklist, shortened by the editors. Readers and listeners come from Drucker, as quoted by Gabarro and Kotter.

More in the essay When to solve it yourself and when to take it higher

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Two views of one relationship

Leader–member exchange (LMX) theory studies each boss–employee pair as a relationship of its own. In 1995 George Graen and Mary Uhl-Bien described how such a relationship can grow in three phases.

LEADERSHIP MAKING, AFTER GRAEN & UHL-BIEN (1995)

01	02	03
Strangers	**Acquaintances**	**Partners**
formal, within the job description	roles are tested, trust grows	mutual trust, respect and obligation

Charlotte Gerstner and David Day found the quality of this relationship tied to performance, satisfaction, commitment, role clarity and the intention to leave, but not to actual leaving. Leaders and members rated it only moderately alike. Hock-Peng Sin and colleagues confirmed this across 64 samples and 10,884 pairs ($\rho = .37$). Agreement was higher in longer relationships; in their own data from 98 pairs, it also rose with more intense contact.

OUR READING

Would your boss describe your working relationship the way you do? Only a conversation will tell you.

Sources: George B. Graen & Mary Uhl-Bien, The Leadership Quarterly 6(2), 1995 (via UF/IFAS Extension, Assessing the Relationship between Supervisors and Employees); Charlotte R. Gerstner & David V. Day, Journal of Applied Psychology 82(6), 1997 (via Abstract); Hock-Peng Sin, Jennifer D. Nahrgang & Frederick P. Morgeson, Journal of Applied Psychology 94(4), 2009 (via Abstract); James H. Dulebohn, William H. Bommer, Robert C. Liden, Robyn L. Brouer & Gerald R. Ferris, Journal of Management 38(6), 2012 (via Abstract)

Meta-analyses of correlations: they show associations, not causes. The phases are confirmed through independent summaries. James Dulebohn and colleagues (247 studies) found the leader's side explains the most; the employee's side counts too.

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Seven questions, two answers

Graen and Uhl-Bien proposed seven questions, LMX-7, each answered on a five-point scale, so the total runs from 7 to 35. Gerstner and Day found it the soundest of the measures they compared. The questions ask, in short:

1. **Where do I stand?**
   Do you know how satisfied the boss is with your work?
2. **Understanding and potential**
   Does the boss understand your problems and see your potential?
3. **Backing**
   Would the boss use their power to help you, even at a cost to themselves?
4. **Trust and the whole**
   Would you defend the boss's decision in their absence? How effective is the relationship?

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A SHIFT LEADER AND HER MANAGER

Her score	22 of 35, lowest on “where do I stand?”
His score	29 of 35
Next step	a monthly talk on what “good” means this quarter

The gap matters more than either score. Case and scores are invented.

Sources: George B. Graen & Mary Uhl-Bien, The Leadership Quarterly 6(2), 1995 (via UF/IFAS Extension, Assessing the Relationship between Supervisors and Employees); Charlotte R. Gerstner & David V. Day, Journal of Applied Psychology 82(6), 1997 (via Abstract); Hock-Peng Sin, Jennifer D. Nahrgang & Frederick P. Morgeson, Journal of Applied Psychology 94(4), 2009 (via Abstract)

Questions paraphrased and grouped by the editors; the original wording was seen only in later reproductions. The boss can answer a matching version about the employee.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The card for the talk with your boss

One card before each regular talk with your manager. Check the first two lines every quarter, the rest each time.

01 Their goals and pressures what their own boss expects of them this quarter

02 How they take information reader or listener; how often, in what form

03 What we expect of each other my draft of their expectations, to check together

04 News they need, including bad news what happened, what I have done, what I need decided

05 Commitments only dates I can keep; what slipped since last time

06 What I will not ask for small things I can settle myself

Sources: John J. Gabarro & John P. Kotter, Harvard Business Review, 1980 (via Best of HBR reprint, January 2005); Frances J. Milliken, Elizabeth W. Morrison & Patricia F. Hewlin, Journal of Management Studies 40(6), 2003 (via Authors' manuscript)

The card is the editors' proposal, built on Gabarro and Kotter's checklist and on Milliken et al.'s work on silence. The handover tool keeps open issues with an owner and a time.

Open the tool: Shift Handover stivencatalyst.com/tools/shift-handover/

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

Managing Your Boss
John J. Gabarro & John P. Kotter, Harvard Business Review, 1980 · via Best of HBR reprint, January 2005
https://hbr.org/2005/01/managing-your-boss

An Exploratory Study of Employee Silence: Issues that Employees Don't Communicate Upward and Why
Frances J. Milliken, Elizabeth W. Morrison & Patricia F. Hewlin, Journal of Management Studies 40(6), 2003 · via Authors' manuscript
https://doi.org/10.1111/1467-6486.00387

Relationship-based approach to leadership: Development of leader-member exchange (LMX) theory of leadership over 25 years
George B. Graen & Mary Uhl-Bien, The Leadership Quarterly 6(2), 1995 · via UF/IFAS Extension, Assessing the Relationship between Supervisors and Employees
https://digitalcommons.unl.edu/managementfacpub/57/

Meta-analytic review of leader-member exchange theory: Correlates and construct issues
Charlotte R. Gerstner & David V. Day, Journal of Applied Psychology 82(6), 1997 · via Abstract
https://doi.org/10.1037/0021-9010.82.6.827

Understanding why they don't see eye to eye: An examination of leader-member exchange (LMX) agreement
Hock-Peng Sin, Jennifer D. Nahrgang & Frederick P. Morgeson, Journal of Applied

A Meta-Analysis of Antecedents and Consequences of Leader-Member Exchange
James H. Dulebohn, William H. Bommer, Robert C. Liden, Robyn L. Brouer & Gerald R. Ferris, Journal of Management 38(6), 2012 ·

CORRECTION · 16 OCTOBER 2026

Sin and colleagues' meta-analysis of 64 samples found higher agreement in longer relationships; that agreement also rose with more intense contact comes from their own data on 98 pairs. The text first credited both to the meta-analysis.

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



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Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

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